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According to Goldstein, how did Jews' increased social integration into the dominant white society after World War II make it easier for them to express empathy for African Americans and support movements for Black civil rights? In what situations were there exceptions to this trend?

social integration

Empathy why
civil rights why
exceptions

CHAPTER 8

WORLD WAR II AND THE TRANSFORMATION OF JEWISH RACIAL IDENTITY

AT THE height of the Depression, Jews in America could scarcely have been more torn about their place in the American racial system. A growing sense of insecurity heightened their identification with blacks even as it pushed them toward whiteness. Increasing attacks from hostile forces intensified their feelings of “racial” pride and solidarity while also underscoring the danger of being seen as distinct in race. With white Americans both demanding the assimilation of the Jews and setting up social barriers that prevented their entry into the white mainstream, there seemed to be little hope that these disturbing tensions would soon disappear.

Yet amid the trials of the 1930s, forces were at work that would ultimately transform the position of American Jews, bringing them much more firmly into the fold of white Americans. Seeking the support of minorities in advancing his New Deal agenda, President Franklin D. Roosevelt increasingly promoted an inclusive nationalism that embraced Jews and other immigrants as productive participants in the national culture. Like his predecessor and cousin, Theodore Roosevelt, he brought many Jews into public service and even admitted some to his small circle of trusted advisers.¹ While there was a significant backlash to the administration’s overtures toward Jews, by the war years there were also an increasing number of non-Jewish Americans who were influenced by the government’s vision and were ready to take immediate steps to admit Jews and other immigrants into the white mainstream. As economic recovery and military successes transformed the United States into a much more hopeful nation during the 1940s and Jews began to vanish as a symbol of social anxiety, this tendency toward greater inclusiveness took hold among white Americans more generally.

In important ways, this dramatic transition relieved the debilitating social pressures Jews had long experienced as unstable members of America’s racial culture. For the first time since the nineteenth century, many Jews felt free to voice empathy and support for African Americans without fear that it would bring their whiteness into question. The shifts of the 1940s also made it easier for Jewish leaders and scholars to promote a new definition of Jewish group difference rooted in “ethnicity,” a con-

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cept that had failed to catch on among Jews as long as they remained victims of “racial” hatred. Yet the acceptance of Jews as unambiguous whites did not totally resolve the dilemmas of asserting a distinctive identity in a society organized around the categories of “black” and “white.” If Jews grew more comfortable embracing racial liberalism, their ongoing desire for acceptance in the non-Jewish world sometimes pushed them to retreat from liberal positions. Even when they did voice concern and support for blacks, they were often unable to assert the specifically Jewish motivations for their posture. Similarly, while their incorporation into white America lessened the stigma attached to Jewish difference, Jews ultimately found the new “ethnic” definition of Jewishness unviable. Unable to satisfy either the emotional needs of Jews, who often continued to think of themselves in racial terms, or meet the expectations of non-Jews, who assumed that postwar Jewishness would fade into a denominational identity, the language of “ethnicity” receded as quickly as it had arisen. Thus, rather than helping them to achieve a satisfying synthesis of American and Jewish identities in the postwar period, Jews’ long-awaited entry into the white mainstream often left them vacillating between forms of self-expression acceptable to the larger white society and more particularistic commitments that could not be comfortably expressed in public.

what did this look like in an American context?

White Americans All

The notion of a “Jewish Problem” had remained strong in both the conservative and liberal streams of American racial discourse during the 1930s. But during the closing years of the decade, some of the dramatic social and political changes that grew out of the Depression and Roosevelt’s New Deal helped legitimize a different, less menacing view of the Jewish place in national life. As both Catholic and Jewish immigrants became a larger and more politically mobilized part of the electorate during these years, Roosevelt began to rely on them more significantly as a base of support for his New Deal agenda. Aside from the Jews he had tapped as political advisers, he forged close relationships with Jewish figures ranging from Rabbi Stephen S. Wise, who was active in social reform movements, to Sidney Hillman, the leader of Jewish-dominated Amalgamated Clothing Workers of America.² Out of these increasing ties came a greater willingness to redefine American nationalism in ways that did not question the status of Jews and other immigrant groups as a stable part of white society. As Roosevelt approached his second term in office, he began to express the view that immigrant groups had become “fully American” and that they no longer presented the thorny problems of assimilation and adjustment that many whites had worried about since the

1920s.³ During his reelection campaign of 1936, Roosevelt strongly asserted the notion that immigrants were an asset, rather than a threat, to American life, going so far as to suggest that “in some cases the newer citizens have discharged their obligations to us better than we have discharged our obligations to them.”⁴

Roosevelt’s vision of a more expansive white America that included Jews and other immigrant groups, however, did not go unchallenged by conservative forces. His political opponents, like Representative Martin J. Dies of Texas, chair of the House Special Committee on Un-American Activities, saw the growing ties between Jews and the Roosevelt Administration as a dangerous development that threatened the integrity of the nation. He frequently charged Jews with being communist sympathizers, taking particularly sharp aim at those who favored civil rights for African Americans.⁵ During the late 1930s and 1940s, Senator Theodore Bilbo and Congressman John Rankin, both of Mississippi, regularly blamed “New York Jews” for the liberal social and racial policies of the New Deal and attacked Jewish congressmen who supported labor reform and desegregation.⁶ Painting Jews as a subversive force in American race relations, Rankin argued that Connecticut congressman Herman Koppelman’s proposal for desegregation in the nation’s capital would encourage black men to attack white women.⁷ The image of the Jews as a group that put its own interests over those of white America found particular expression after 1939, when conservatives pointed to Jewish influence as the force pushing the Roosevelt Administration toward war in Europe. This view was expressed by radio priest Charles Coughlin, who helped popularize it among urban Catholics, as well as by profascist groups like the William Pelley’s Silver Shirts and Gerald Winrod’s Defenders of the Christian Faith. Even more respected figures, like American icon Charles Lindbergh, joined in such rhetoric under the aegis of the America First Committee, one of the most vocal of antiwar organizations. After the United States entered the war, antisemitism continued to increase, reaching what historian Leonard Dinnerstein has called its “high tide.”⁸

Yet even as the war provided a context for increased antisemitism, it also set the scene for a stronger assertion of Roosevelt’s inclusive nationalism. Success in war demanded unity, and Roosevelt and his administration resolved to fight against intergroup hostilities that might threaten the cohesion of American fighting forces or jeopardize efforts on the homefront. The government was particularly concerned that the Germans or their domestic sympathizers would try to weaken American resolve by disseminating propaganda designed to inflame racial hatreds. As a result, it took strong action against racist agitators, charging many with undermining the war effort and espousing an enemy ideology. In 1942, profascists Pelley and Winrod were investigated for sedition and their publications were

Even though Roosevelt's actions benefited Jews + Catholics, it was popularization among Catholics intentional? Was it meant to drive a wedge between recently accepted groups?

which groups were affected by this?

shut down. The same year, government officials put strong pressure on the Catholic Church to silence Father Coughlin, who ceased to broadcast his sermons under the threat of suspension from church leaders.⁹

In addition to the suppression of racist publications and spokesmen, the government also engaged in a vigorous propaganda campaign, which promoted its goal of unity by defining the American values of tolerance and equality as the antithesis of Nazi racism. The roots of these efforts stretched back to the immediate prewar years, when the U.S. Office of Education, already fearing the deleterious effect of fascist propaganda in the United States, initiated a series of radio broadcasts entitled “Americans All . . . Immigrants All.” After the entry of the United States into the war, propaganda denouncing racial hatred as “un-American” became a centerpiece of efforts to mobilize the home front and was disseminated widely by the newly formed Office of War Information (OWI), not only on the airwaves but also through pamphlets, posters, films, and even comic books.¹⁰

As the fight against racial discrimination became identified with the war aims, some government agencies took steps to discard the terminology of “race” as it applied to European immigrant groups. The Immigration and Naturalization Service (INS), for example, created new forms for naturalization in 1940 that recorded European immigrants’ race as “white” rather than employing the narrower racial designations traditionally used in the immigration records. New arrivals from Europe continued to be classified on ships’ manifests according to the old “List of Races and Peoples” until the 1950s, but in 1943 a special exception was made for Jews, who ceased to be written down as “Hebrews.” Apparently, repeated requests by Jewish organizations and the desire to distance government classification schemes from those used by the Nazis pushed the INS commissioner, Earl H. Harrison, to finally reconsider the decades-old policy, which he now described as arbitrary and without foundation in American law.¹¹

The tolerance campaigns of the World War II era often decried discrimination in the broadest terms, condemning racism against African Americans as well as against those of various immigrant backgrounds. In practice, however, by offering a much greater degree of incorporation to Jews and other European groups than to blacks, the government’s wartime policies had the effect of redrawing American racial boundaries rather than erasing them altogether. Ultimately, the Roosevelt Administration believed that domestic stability would best be achieved by consolidating immigrants into the “white” population and by reestablishing the clear division between blacks and whites that had been in doubt in American society for several decades. This process of stabilizing the black-white divide was most evident in the organization of American military forces, where blacks and Asians were segregated into their own units while Jews,

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WWII
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them to think
this?

Gover Ament
promoted unity
in war by consolidating whiteness

Italians, and Irish were assigned to “white” units along with men whose families had been in the United States for generations.¹² The existence of a Pacific warfront where the Japanese enemy was defined as a nonwhite racial menace also gave credence to the notion of a unified white American fighting force.¹³ More than any other wartime development, the thorough integration of Jews and Catholics into the American military helped cement the public’s view of these groups as unambiguously white.

Although they were never embraced universally by the American public, the government’s attempts to both counter prejudice and stabilize racial boundaries helped relieve much anxiety about the place of Jews in national life. This shift was apparent in the growing authority with which liberal intellectuals were able to dispel the notion of a distinct Jewish “race” and introduce new concepts concerning group difference within American culture during these years. Though anthropologist Franz Boas had been unsuccessful in rallying the scientific community to discredit Nazi racial theory in the mid-1930s, by 1938 he was able to convince the American Anthropological Society to pass a resolution stating that the terms “Aryan” and “Semite” had “no racial significance whatsoever,” and were useful only in identifying linguistic groups.¹⁴ By the early 1940s, anthropological theories that questioned the applicability of the term “race” to European groups were popularized in book form, and certain titles, like Ruth Benedict’s *Races of Mankind* and Ashley Montagu’s *Man’s Most Dangerous Myth*, became bestsellers. As the term “race” came to be applied more exclusively to peoples of color, concepts like “ethnicity,” pioneered by Jewish scholars in the 1920s to refer to European descent groups, were finally introduced more broadly to the American public. When sociologists W. Lloyd Warner and Leo Srole contributed a volume on immigrant adjustment to the acclaimed “Yankee City” series in 1945, they distinguished sharply between nonwhite “racial” groups and white “ethnic” groups. While ethnic groups may carry “a divergent set of cultural traits which are evaluated by the host society as inferior,” they explained, “racial groups are divergent biologically rather than culturally.”¹⁵ These changes in terminology were not only discernible in the writings of liberal intellectuals. In public opinion polls carried out just after the war, less than half of Americans surveyed still identified the Jews as a race, a sharp decline from the prewar tendency.¹⁶

The inclusive nationalism of the Roosevelt Administration, the integration of Jews into the U.S. military, and the spread of new theories about the difference between “race” and “ethnicity” all paved the way for Jews to gain acceptance as American whites during the war years. Yet ultimately, it was not until the Allied victory ushered in a new period of optimism and social stability that the Jew ceased to operate as a significant symbol of social anxiety. Despite the somewhat gradual pace of Jewish

incorporation into white America, however, Jews themselves responded enthusiastically to the increased climate of acceptance from the beginning. Having experienced more than four decades of uncertainty about their place in America's racial culture, Jews of the late 1930s and 1940s were exhilarated by the promise of integration represented by these liberal forces. Despite the persistence of antisemitism during the war years, the willingness of an increasing number of white Americans to oppose anti-Jewish sentiments and declare them antithetical to the nation's values inspired great optimism among American Jews that they would finally be able to achieve unconditional recognition as full members of the dominant society.

If the events of World War II helped to diminish concern about the far-reaching racial characteristics of Jews and offered them a significant level of incorporation into white America, however, these changes did not reflect a growing comfort with Jewish group separatism. Popular discourse of the 1940s may have transformed the perceived "racial" differences of immigrant groups into "ethnic" ones and parted with references to Jews as a distinct "problem" that needed solving, but in granting ethnics equal rights and opportunities, explains historian Gary Gerstle, promoters of tolerance still "hoped to pull them out of their parochial ethnic worlds and into a cosmopolitan American society."¹⁷ This meant that as Jews integrated into the white mainstream, they were expected to keep expressions of group difference at a level that would not offend the sense of unity and homogeneity from which whites of the postwar era drew their confidence and stability.¹⁸ Yet because white society welcomed them with the language of tolerance and equality, Jews were not always aware of just how exacting the requirements of life in white America would be.

The Rise of Jewish Racial Liberalism

As long as Jewish racial status had remained problematic in American culture, Jews faced continual dilemmas about how to assert their whiteness without adopting forms of white racism that sat uneasily with their own self-image as a persecuted people. But as white Americans' fears about the racial status of Jews began to recede, so did much of the tension surrounding the Jewish approach toward African Americans. In fact, for many Jews pursuing social acceptance during this period, whiteness and racial liberalism often became two mutually supporting aspects of their emerging identities.

The improving image of the Jews among white Americans was not the only factor that helped ease them into a comfortable white identity. Also critical was the way in which the changing social climate of the period

created new possibilities for defining how “whiteness” might be expressed. While Roosevelt’s social policies did not offer blacks the same degree of incorporation into national life that they extended to Jews and other European immigrant groups, the administration did devote considerable effort to ending various forms of racial discrimination and improving conditions for the black working class, goals that many Jews had long shared. Through their support of these measures, and more generally through their overwhelming affiliation with the Democratic Party, American Jews could for the first time claim an unambiguous role in the white mainstream while also pursuing a liberal approach to racial issues. Jews also embraced this liberal version of whiteness by participating in the wartime discourse that condemned all forms of racism and bigotry as “un-American.” With the defeat of racial hatred identified as one of the war aims, Jews felt confident that they could oppose antiblack measures in the name of American principles without making their specifically Jewish motivations public. As a result, they were able to satisfy the emotional need they often had to distance themselves from white racism and yet avoid the stigma of associating themselves too directly with African Americans and their plight.

The letters and memoirs of Jewish servicemen provide some of the earliest examples of how wartime Jews explained their opposition to racism by invoking American ideals without calling attention to their Jewishness or singling themselves out in any way from the white mainstream. Writing home in 1944, Manny Kruppin of Los Angeles complained that the racism of some of his fellow soldiers showed an ignorance of “what we are fighting for and what some of our boys are dying for.” He expressed his hope that “these petty grievances are forgotten and we all concentrate on our common enemy—fascism—and eradicate it forever.”¹⁹ A soldier who submitted his wartime memoirs to a competition sponsored by the YIVO Institute argued that Jews’ role as “citizens” required them to promote “tolerance and mutual understanding” and help find solutions to “the questions of prejudice and discrimination against the colored people, Mexicans and other minority groups.”²⁰ Morris Palansky of Chicago expressed his belief in a 1943 letter that the fight against Hitler demanded similar action against the persecution of blacks at home. Defeating the “breeders of chauvinism and fascism” in America, he explained, went “hand and hand with their defeat abroad.”²¹

At home, too, American Jews condemned racism against blacks by invoking broad American principles rather than specifically Jewish rationales. The National Council of Jewish Women, which began to oppose discrimination against a number of American racial minorities during the war years, explained its interest in these causes by stating that “the problem of discrimination is the problem of every American.”²² To link their

Purple
= general
anti-racism

Alignment/whiteness → avoid stigma

antiracist attitudes more firmly to the nation's fight against Germany, Jews often compared domestic racism to Nazism. When important hearings meant to address discrimination in railroad employment were canceled due to pressure from southern congressmen, Brooklyn's *Jewish Examiner* argued that Hitler, while losing the military campaign, could "take comfort in this triumph of fascism on the American domestic front." The paper urged the southerners to address the paradox of "fighting against the detestable Nazi doctrine of race superiority overseas while they fight for the right to keep it alive on these shores."²³ In the final years of the war, the Greensboro, North Carolina, *American Jewish Times* took aim at the racism of Senator Theodore Bilbo and Congressman John Rankin, calling them the "Shame of Mississippi" for their "un-American spirit." Public opinion should be mobilized to force such men out of office, argued the paper, lest the United States "allow the Nazis and other kindred spirits to laugh up their sleeves at our democracy."²⁴

Ultimately, this new civic discourse, which allowed Jews to speak with the authority of full Americans while also condemning all forms of racial discrimination as "un-American" and antidemocratic, was embraced by the major Jewish defense agencies in the United States, including the American Jewish Committee, the American Jewish Congress, and the Anti-Defamation League of B'nai B'rith. In the years following World War II, these agencies often shifted their focus away from the narrow defense of Jewish interests and instead set their sights on more "generalized" forms of prejudice.²⁵ New York State Supreme Court Judge Meier Steinbrink, who assumed the national chairmanship of the Anti-Defamation League in the immediate postwar period, explained: "as Jewish agencies we will be concerned not so much with protecting the position of the Jews as with expanding the business of democracy so that all who live in America shall enjoy equally of the rights, obligations, and opportunities which America offers."²⁶ In theory, the fight against "generalized prejudice" was meant to attack intolerance against all minorities rather than focusing specifically on the plight of any one group. Yet because African Americans remained the most visible outsiders in American society and Jews were quickly becoming indistinct among white Americans, these campaigns often had the effect of highlighting the black-white divide while obscuring Jewish distinctiveness. This approach to civil rights was also taken up by the leading unions in the garment industry, which still had a strong Jewish leadership in the 1940s despite a decline in the number of Jewish members. While the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union had long fought for the rights of Jewish workers, its **tolerance campaigns of the 1940s decried bigotry and racism in ways that cast Americans as blacks and whites and made Jewishness invisible. Such activism allowed Jews to identify vicariously with the civil rights' struggle**



21. "The Defense of Equal Rights," 1947. Racial liberalism gave many Jews of the World War II era a means to express their empathy for African Americans while downplaying their own role as victims of "racial" hatred. In this publicity sketch for the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union, Jews become undifferentiated whites as they join with blacks to fight bigotry and intolerance. (From Max Danish, *The Story of the ILGWU*. Sketch by Bernard Seaman)

becaus asking of ourself as a victim no matter makes you white hater?

of blacks without putting into question the strides they had made toward acceptance as unambiguous whites.²⁷

There were, however, exceptions to the way Jewish discourse tended to obscure the particular investment Jews had in battling racism during this period. During the war years, the raw emotions concerning Jewish persecution in Europe and the ongoing pressures of domestic antisemitism sometimes pushed Jews to be more explicit about their reasons for opposing antiblack racism and occasionally led them to make direct comparisons between themselves and African Americans. In 1941, just before America's entry into the conflict, Rabbi Alexander Goode, who later became a symbol of interfaith cooperation as an army chaplain who died in service along with three non-Jewish colleagues, spoke of the "jim crow" policies endured by Europe's Jews and used the history of Jewish persecution to argue against the segregation of African Americans in his hometown of Washington, D.C.²⁸ Similarly, when a grand jury in New York's Kings County Court handed down a presentment tinged with antiblack racism, the Brooklyn *Jewish Examiner* argued that "no one is in a better position to sympathize with and understand its harsh unfairness than Jews."²⁹ These statements, however, were deviations from the general wartime practice of keeping the Jewish motivations for antiracist attitudes submerged, a trend that became even more pronounced as Jews made

strides toward greater social integration in the postwar period. Jews did continue to compare antiblack racism with Nazi policies during the immediate postwar years, but in doing so they generally described Nazi racism not as a specifically Jewish travail but as a synonym for bigotry or hatred more generally. Since Nazism was widely seen as antithetical to “American values,” Jewish commentators could describe white attackers of African Americans as “perfect Hitler material” or compare Jim Crow policies with the racism of the “brownshirts” without ever directly acknowledging the links they were making between blacks and Jews.³⁰ Rather than explicitly positioning themselves as a minority group like African Americans, Jews generally used blacks and black causes as surrogates for concerns that had become less immediate in their own lives, but to which they retained a strong emotional connection.

As racial liberalism began to permeate the discourse and institutions of the American Jewish community, Jews of the war years and the immediate postwar period also began to express their new approach to African Americans through the consumption of popular culture. Whereas the Jewish encounter with black culture during the 1920s and 1930s had revealed intense ambivalence, and often combined longing admiration with a defensive racism, by the 1940s Jews seem to have evolved a more confident cultural style that gave them access to black culture without fear that it would stigmatize them as outsiders. Countless memoirs record the fascination of Jewish youth of these years with African American jazz artists, whose performances in nightclubs and dance halls they would often attend. Many young Jews accorded these musicians the status of cultural icons, speaking of them with a reverence that stands in marked contrast to the mixed emotions Jewish youth had expressed about black culture just a decade earlier. Jews of this period often found that jazz could give them the sense of freedom and individuality they desired in white America without threatening their newfound status in that society. As historian Lawrence Levine recalled of his youth during this period, “through these jazz musicians we not only found art that touched us, we also saw the possibility of functioning in the outside society while retaining our individual and ethnic personas.”³¹

The increasing ease with which Jews expressed their respect and admiration for black musicians mirrored a similar development in their approach to African American sports figures. Jewish men of the 1920s and 1930s had often become involved in sports as a means of countering antisemitic stereotypes, using athletic competition to demonstrate the strength and talent of the “Jewish race” and to win approval from the dominant society. As Jews of the 1940s felt less pressure to prove themselves in the ring and on the playing field, however, they often began to rally around the rising generation of African American athletes who were coming to take their

place as participants in professional athletics and whose struggle for recognition seemed to recall their own experiences.³² After Jackie Robinson broke the color barrier in major league baseball in 1947 and paved the way for the entry of other black players into the national game, the *American Hebrew* expressed its pleasure that “America’s unrealized ideal of equality” was “becoming a reality in the sports world.”³³ Similarly, Jews of this period often saw the African American heavyweight Joe Louis as a successor to Jewish boxing greats such as Barney Ross and Benny Leonard.³⁴ They also took pride in the fact that Louis’s Jewish manager, Mike Jacobs, played an important role in the black fighter’s rise to prominence, thereby delivering a “terrific blow,” as the *Hebrew* explained, not only to those who “wanted a white man to maintain the legend of white supremacy” but to the entire “theory of race supremacy” in general.³⁵ As had happened in the realm of civil rights, African Americans had largely become an emotional surrogate for concerns that were no longer primary in the experience of American Jews themselves.

If the social transformation of the World War II era made it possible for many Jews to assert a racial liberalism that did not threaten their status as white in American society, these developments did not succeed in totally solving the tensions and contradictions embedded in the American Jewish approach to African Americans. Instead, two significant problems continued to complicate Jews’ attempts to synthesize their Jewish and white identities. First, although Jews were finding a comfortable niche in American politics and life, they generally remained more liberal than most other white Americans, from whom they continued to seek gestures of social acceptance. As a result, they sometimes continued to feel pushed in opposite directions by the social pressures encountered in their new settings. According to Deborah Dash Moore, Jewish soldiers entering basic training at the beginning of the war sometimes acceded to the antiblack racism of their comrades in order to avoid calling unwanted attention to themselves. In Fort Benning, Georgia, Howard Sachs was shocked when one of his fellow trainees punched a black man who didn’t move off the sidewalk fast enough for him to pass. Yet as a Jew trying to establish his own credentials in a new arena, he felt he was in no position to object to such behavior.³⁶

During the postwar years, the most obvious example of an ongoing struggle among Jews over their approach to African Americans was in the South. Southern Jews, unlike their counterparts in most other regions, generally shied away from visible support for black civil rights, fearing such a stance would incur the wrath of white neighbors. Although some southern Jews like Atlanta rabbi Jacob Rothschild and Jackson, Mississippi, rabbi Perry Nussbaum did make common cause with African Americans, others like Georgia politician Charles Bloch and South Caro-

to gain acceptance from white whiteness
How profoundly did this conflict w/ emotional values?

lina legislator Sol Blatt strongly supported the segregationist status quo.³⁷ Ultimately, while most Southern Jews seem to have had a greater degree of empathy for African Americans than did their gentile counterparts, most were too fearful of negative social consequences to express such feelings openly. In a few cases, Jewish businessmen in small southern towns were sufficiently moved by feelings of insecurity and duress to join the local “white citizens councils,” which actively opposed integration. “Faced with social ostracism, economic boycott and the occasional death threat,” explains historian Clive Webb, “they had little alternative.”³⁸ As civil rights activity heated up in the South, a few “quiet voices” worked diligently for social change, but by and large the sympathies of the Jewish community for blacks remained muted by a climate of fear.³⁹

Northern Jews, too, sometimes found themselves constrained in their support of civil rights by a desire to continue their strides toward social acceptance. When their support of civil rights brought them into conflict with powerful white elites or when residential proximity to African Americans threatened their social status, they often retreated from their policy of racial liberalism and supported the path that best facilitated their continued integration into the white mainstream.⁴⁰ In the years directly following the war, for example, tensions continued to emerge in changing urban neighborhoods concerning the questions of racial proximity and succession. In 1949, about fifty-five thousand Jews remained in Chicago’s Lawndale district, where they lived alongside a population of ten thousand African Americans. Despite the avoidance of racial violence and the foundation of a “citizen’s council”—not to be confused with its southern counterparts—that worked to ensure good race relations, community officials reported that “the vast majority of Jews in the area have a tremendous resentment towards the new residents.”⁴¹ In addition, Lawndale organizations like the Jewish People’s Institute (JPI) became embroiled in controversy over whether local African Americans should be allowed to use the pool, attend the day camp, or attend the evening dances frequented by local Jewish youth. On one occasion a radical group invited several African Americans to a dance at the JPI, much to the dismay of some of the other Jewish attendees. While affirming their commitment to a policy of nondiscrimination and democracy in an official statement, leaders of the JPI expressed concerns that if they admitted blacks to their events in any large numbers, “the vast majority of . . . Jewish membership would promptly withdraw.”⁴²

Such tensions failed to dissipate as Jews left behind urban neighborhoods for more suburban locations. While a panoply of national Jewish organizations like the American Jewish Committee, the American Jewish Congress, B’nai B’rith, the Jewish War Veterans, and the Jewish Labor Committee all supported legislation against housing restriction, many

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Jewish suburbanites found themselves in the somewhat uncomfortable position of supporting neighborhood covenants. The Jewish developer William Levitt, who built model "Levittown" communities in New Jersey and Pennsylvania during the mid-1950s, refused to integrate his communities until he was forced to do so by the courts in 1960. Levitt argued that "as a Jew and a humane man he sympathized with the plight of struggling minorities," but that because "most whites prefer not to live in mixed communities," he could not be expected to undertake such a "vast social experiment" as building integrated suburbs. Levitt faced pressure from Jewish groups, but according to sociologist Herbert Gans, Jews whose own social status was endangered by the threat of proximity to African Americans often shared the developers' ambivalent view. "I don't want Negroes in Levittown, and I don't want Jews associated with inter-racial attempts," explained one Jewish Levittowner. As a Jew, however, the same individual refused to picket against impending integration, explaining that "we are a minority, too."⁴³ Although Jews' success in the postwar world helped them assert a more consistent support of black rights than had been possible in the 1920s and 1930s, such examples illustrate how their racial liberalism could give way under the ongoing pressures of integration.⁴⁴

If their commitment to liberal values was sometimes challenged by their continued drive for social acceptance, Jews also encountered a second stumbling block in trying to synthesize their Jewish and white identities: the ultimate inability of racial liberalism to convey the full distinctiveness of Jewish concerns. True, many Jews felt racial liberalism to be a natural outgrowth of their own history as a persecuted people, and they devoted their community institutions to its cause. But the tendency of Jews during this period to cast their opposition to racism as an outgrowth of "American values" and to downplay the specifically Jewish motivations for such views reflected the constraints placed on them by their entrance into white society. Racial liberalism and intergroup relations work often served their identity needs as they sought greater inclusion in white America, but over the long run these commitments failed to provide the sense of particularity Jews once felt among America's constellation of "racial" groups. As we shall see, while incorporation into white America allowed Jews to put a difficult period of antisemitism behind them, it also severely limited their ability to articulate an identity as a group apart.

The Retreat of Jewish Racial Identity

In the mid-1930s, Jews had struggled with the limits of an identity rooted in race, often pushed by growing antisemitism toward strong defenses of

their racial character but worried that they might further endanger their position with such separatist rhetoric. As wartime culture increasingly allowed Jews to position themselves as unambiguous whites, however, they no longer felt compelled to appeal to racial pride in answering the charges of their critics. At a time when the government was signaling its disapproval of antisemitism and the U.S. Office of Education was sponsoring programs recognizing the contributions of groups like Jews to American life, it became increasingly clear to Jews that they could condemn the actions of their enemies by invoking the principles of Americanism, rather than engaging in risky debates about their own racial qualities. In many ways, the goal of fighting antisemitism was pursued through the same universalized discourse that Jews used to oppose racism of all kinds. In condemning “race prejudice” as “un-American,” Jews were able to answer their accusers while drawing only minimal attention to themselves. As Jewish defense agencies began during the war years to carry on campaigns against “generalized prejudice” and to label all forms of racism as the antithesis of American democracy, the need for defensive assertions of Jewish racial identity vanished.

A willingness to put aside strong expressions of racial pride during the war years, however, did not mean that American Jews wished to obscure their group distinctiveness altogether. Buoyed by what they saw as the ability to finally meld their Jewish identity with white Americanism, several Jewish community leaders of the war years—mainly rabbis—set out to popularize a new version of group identity more suited to the changing social circumstances. In a number of books and pamphlets issued between the late 1930s and the end of the war, these writers began to forward a new cultural or “ethnic” brand of Jewishness similar to that first suggested by Jewish scholars in the 1920s and early 1930s. Unlike the more technical, academic treatises produced by Horace Kallen, Julius Drachler, Isaac Berkson, and Mordecai Kaplan, however, arguments for an ethnic Jewishness during this period were usually written in a popular style and intended for broad circulation.

One of the leading proponents of the ethnic definition of Jewishness during these years was Lee Levinger, a Reform rabbi from Wilmington, Delaware, who had studied the history and causes of American antisemitism as a graduate student at the University of Pennsylvania during the 1920s. In 1936, Levinger argued in a book about antisemitism that the Jews’ common traits were “social, religious and national” rather than racial, and were a product of “social heredity, which we ordinarily call tradition.”⁴⁵ Sensing the opportunity to bring these views to a wider audience during the war years, he collaborated with James Waterman Wise, the son of Rabbi Stephen S. Wise, to issue *Mr. Smith Meets Mr. Cohen* (1940), a book intended to promote better understanding between Jews

But this reinforces racism, it just re-aligns Jews as white

and non-Jews. Although Wise had previously asserted a racial understanding of Jewishness, he and Levinger now argued unambiguously that the Jew was not distinct in race, but was “a member of a recognizable minority group—set apart by his religion, language, nationality, [and] other characteristics.”⁴⁶ By 1945, Conservative rabbi Milton Steinberg, in his *Partisan Guide to the Jewish Problem*, proposed the term “people” as a more suitable label for the Jewish group than race. “A people is a body of persons who partake together in a social past and its heritage, a present and its problems, a future and its aspirations,” explained Steinberg. While peoplehood was “marked by a sense of kinship and shared interests,” however, it differed significantly from race. “‘Race’ as applied to humans,” he wrote, “is the analogue of ‘breed’ in reference to animals . . . [and] is altogether inapplicable to Jewry.”⁴⁷ Another popular book of the period, written by Reform rabbi Roland B. Gittelsohn for use in high school classes and Jewish youth groups, presented a number of new alternatives to the racial definition, including “civilization,” “community,” “people,” and “cultural group.”⁴⁸

In their efforts to advance this new “ethnic” version of Jewishness and discredit the notion of a “Jewish race” among Jews, popularizers were aided by the increasing association of racial language with the Nazi regime. Although Jews had rarely if ever advanced a view of Jewish racial distinctiveness as absolute as the one the Nazis proposed, Levinger and his colleagues made the argument that embracing a racial definition of Jewishness was tantamount to accepting Nazi racial dogmas. In 1936, Levinger used such logic to dismiss a racial view of group identity as nothing more than “a device to bolster up anti-Semitism or other types of national or group hatred.” Condemning the racial generalizations made by Jews as strongly as those made by non-Jews, he argued that the chauvinistic views of writers such as Maurice Samuel and David Goldblatt were nothing more a reversal of the Nazi race theories.⁴⁹ A similar emphasis was made in 1943 by Gittelsohn, who was still willing to argue that Jews were “in some ways” a race, but was certain to “distinguish clearly between our use of that word and Hitler’s use of it.” According to Gittelsohn, Hitler relied on the notion that races were relatively pure and thus could be easily placed in categories of superior and inferior. “That is why we Jews, if we use the word race in describing ourselves, must be careful to say ‘a race in some respects’ or ‘to some extent a race.’”⁵⁰

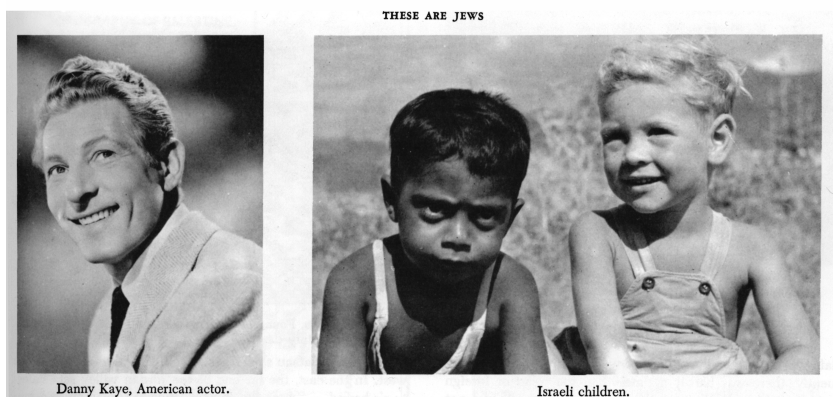
While the comparison to Nazi racial dogmas was an effective tool in discrediting a racial view of Jewishness, spokesmen for Jewish ethnicity also based their arguments on the growing American consensus that the only true racial distinctions were those based on color. Such reasoning was featured in a booklet distributed in 1939 by the Anti-Defamation League for use in its “Fireside Discussion Group,” a popular home-study

course aimed at educating Jews about “the many problems confronting World Jewry.” To support its assertion of Jewish whiteness, the guide strained to downplay race among the elements contributing to Jewish identity. “Scientifically and correctly speaking, there are three great races in the world: the black, yellow and white,” the guide explained. “Within the white race all the sub-races have long since been mixed and we Jews are part of the general admixture.” Environmental influences, however “made us a distinctive type, and a common spiritual culture has made us a conscious unity. Approximately a race, definitely a type, and consciously a unity, we are an historic people.”⁵¹

The broad acceptance of this view was made clear in 1943 when the YIVO Institute for Jewish Research in New York surveyed prominent academics of Jewish origin on the perennial issue of whether Jews should be classified as “Hebrews” in U.S. immigration records. Most of the respondents suggested that the term “ethnic group” be substituted for race, which they felt should only be used in reference to peoples of color. “Any subdivisions smaller than White (or Caucasian), Negro, Mongolian are objectionable to me,” wrote University of Chicago sociologist Louis Wirth. “I think these categories are sufficient for the human race.” Max Schoen, a psychologist and educator from the Carnegie Institute of Technology, echoed the sentiments of many of those surveyed when he wrote that “the term ‘race’ other than *white*, *black*, etc., is now utterly meaningless.”⁵² Schoen’s statement captured the tenor of American Jewish discourse on both the scholarly and popular levels. By the war’s end in 1945, it was exceedingly rare for Jews to still refer to themselves as a “race.”

Although Jewish racial identity was increasingly refashioned as “ethnicity” during the late 1930s and 1940s, this semantic shift failed to provide a complete solution to the tensions embedded in American Jewish identity. Significantly, the disappearance of “race” as a term for self-definition among American Jews by 1945 did not necessarily mean that Jews ceased to think of themselves in racial terms. The tendency of ethnic promoters to use multiple, somewhat vague terms (“people,” “civilization,” “community”) for Jewish difference without settling on any one clear description signified the difficulty they had in filling the gap left by the disappearance of “race.” The imprecision with which they sometimes differentiated the new concepts of group status from the old (Jews remained “in some respects a race” or “approximately a race”) suggests that the change in terminology was not accompanied by a significant change in the way Jews understood what made them different. Ironically, in some ways the older racial definition ended up having greater utility than the newer ethnic understanding of Jewishness for Jews poised on the brink of social acceptance. The ethnic definition stressed a set of shared cultural practices and an interest in things like Jewish art, literature, and music.

still re-enforcing racial division
why were they still arguing this consideration
the mark away from scientific racism at the same time?



22. "These Are Jews," 1953. Nathan Ausubel's popular *Pictorial History of the Jewish People* depicted its subjects as stemming from a variety of races, reflecting the tendency of postwar Jews to move away from references to the "Jewish race." Some wartime Jewish spokesmen tried to popularize a new "ethnic" identity among American Jews, but by the 1950s it was the religious version of Jewishness that flourished the most in public discourse.

Yet American Jews hoping to make significant strides toward social integration were much more focused on emulating the cultural patterns of their non-Jewish neighbors than on developing their own distinctive cultural repertoire. As they pursued integration, they were often drawn to a more primordial understanding of Jewishness that had little to do with actual behavior but which privileged blood ties and gave them a sense of connectedness as social boundaries changed.

Signs of a lingering attachment to "race" can be seen in the cultural production of American Jews during the war years and in the period following. The urge to trumpet the achievements of fellow Jews, for example, remained intact even after the language of race had disappeared in Jewish circles. Several books published in the 1940s hailed the talents of Jews as fighters and praised their bravery on the battlefield, even though they scrupulously avoided any overt reference to racial traits.⁵³ Similarly, in his 1944 treatment of antisemitism, *Must Men Hate?* longtime Anti-Defamation League president Sigmund Livingston argued the notion of a separate Jewish race while at the same time engaging in a classic racial apologetic. Starting with the premises that "there is no Aryan, or German, blood and there is no Semitic, or Jewish, blood," Livingston went on to tout the Jews' special "contributions to civilization," even including a list of seven hundred of the world's most accomplished Jews in the back as an appendix. The list employed a purely racial definition of Jewishness, in which

the ancestry of the contributor, rather than the substance of his or her accomplishments, is what made them Jewish. In fact, because Livingston's goal was to show how Jewish traits had helped make Jews contributors to the larger society, those involved in specifically Jewish activities—rabbis, communal leaders, Hebrew and Yiddish authors—were excluded.⁵⁴ Similar works, like Mac Davis's *Jews at a Glance*, which offered a “gallery of Jewish greatness and achievement,” appeared as late as 1956.⁵⁵ The tendency, even at this late date, to define Jews as a group bound by unique qualities and ancestral ties rather than by particular cultural markers suggests that the rise of “ethnicity” did not represent a thoroughgoing reconceptualization of Jewish identity. Instead, it was largely a linguistic strategy designed to recast their continued attachment to a racial self-understanding in terms more acceptable to the non-Jewish world.

The new ethnic definition of Jewishness not only failed to satisfy the emotional needs of many Jews, but also fell short of the expectations of non-Jewish society that Jews would suppress all but religious expressions of group difference as they integrated. While wartime culture had helped distinguish ethnicity from race, it did not necessarily see ethnic difference as a value in and of itself that was worth preserving. On the contrary, during the war years and in the postwar period, white Americans often saw the continued social and cultural separatism of groups like Jews as a divisive and “ethnocentric” force.⁵⁶ Religion, however, was seen as an acceptable form of group cohesion that did not threaten the image of a white America bound together by shared values. During the war, for example, the army promoted the notion of a common “Judeo-Christian tradition” and encouraged white military personnel to organize into faith groups.⁵⁷ By the 1950s, American popular culture—including the emerging medium of television—avoided celebrations of ethnic distinctiveness but valorized religious pluralism. As Will Herberg explained in his now-classic treatment of the period, *Protestant-Catholic-Jew* (1955), religion rather than ethnicity was the primary means through which groups like Jews could stake an equal claim to “The American Way of Life.” Self-identification in ethnic terms, he wrote, was a “sign of incomplete integration.” Any ethnic group that “becomes permanent and self-perpetuating and resists cultural assimilation . . . would be confronted with the same problems and difficulties as face the Negroes and men and women of Oriental ancestry in this country.”⁵⁸

All of these factors undermined the viability of a new “ethnic” identity for American Jews in the years following the war. Instead of creating the neat synthesis between Jewish particularism and white Americanism envisioned by ethnic promoters, Jews often defined themselves publicly as a religious group while privately pursuing Jewishness as a tribal phenomenon. If they sought to become undifferentiated Americans on the



23. Protestant, Catholic, Jew . . . and Negro, 1942. The U.S. military encouraged members of various European descent groups to cast their identities in religious instead of racial terms during World War II. African Americans, who remained segregated in the armed forces, however, continued to stand in distinction to white Protestants, Catholics, and Jews. Here, in a photo taken by the Office of War Information, army chaplains from the three white religious groupings greet an African American colleague. (Courtesy Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division)

suburban frontier, they often restricted their most intimate contacts to other Jews. They gathered primarily in synagogues, but usually to socialize rather than to pray. In fact, a strong preference for friendship and marriage within the Jewish group remained among the most salient features of Jewish life.⁵⁹ Rhetorically, American Jews of the period tended to interpret the Jewish experience by drawing out its broad, humanistic implications. More often than not they described the Holocaust as an event of universal moral significance rather than as a particularist tragedy and frequently spoke of Israel as a land of religious and democratic values rather than as an anchor for Jewish group consciousness.⁶⁰ But despite the religious and universalistic turn of American Jewish discourse in the postwar period, at bottom it was still the basic commitment to Jewish social identity and peoplehood—once articulated in the language of “race”—that animated most Jews. Thus, despite the great strides of social acceptance Jews had made in the postwar years, they often re-

mained unable to square their own self-image with the slot American society had provided for them.

As the experience of Jews in postwar America made clear, achieving the status of whites had not resolved their uneasy relationship to American racial culture. Racial liberalism had failed to totally solve the sense of tension between Jews' desire for both integration and distinctiveness, just as ethnic and religious definitions of Jewishness failed to bridge the gap between their intense group consciousness and the demands of white society. Still, for most Jews of the period, these contradictions never became a matter of excessive concern or worry. As long as their primary goal was further integration, Jews did not generally feel the need to loudly assert their strong group consciousness. Most were perfectly happy to describe themselves as a religious community even as they privately functioned as much more. And while Jews sometimes retreated from their policy of racial liberalism, it remained intact often enough to give Jews the vicarious sense of difference they desired as they continued their drive for inclusion in white America. By the mid-1960s, however, communal priorities began to shift. As the consensus politics of the postwar years collapsed, and the emergence of black nationalist movements redefined whiteness in ways that made Jews increasingly uncomfortable, Jews began to feel the need to assert their group distinctiveness more strongly. This urge only grew during the ensuing decades, when Jews began to worry about the erosion of Jewish social ties and rising rates of assimilation and intermarriage. In responding to these challenges, however, they would have to confront the ways in which their embrace of whiteness had circumscribed their expressions of group distinctiveness.